

Stop Before You Shop



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CONFOUNDED PHONES

Although India entered the cell phone party late, figures by the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) peg the number of mobile subscribers at a whopping 653.92 million users (as of May 2010).

Also, mobile devices sales in the country is expected to reach 138.6 million in 2010 which is an 18.5 per cent increase over 2009 sales, according to market research firm Gartner. You can purchase a phone for as low as ₹2,000 to as high as ₹40,000. Then, how do you go about making the right purchase decision?

This festive season, we're going to help you spend your money wisely. Whether you're buying a little cell phone or a massive HDTV, be sure to spend wisely, and arm yourself with the information on these pages.

THE TECHNOLOGY: 3G

BSNL and MTNL have already started 3G services whereas the other players have given a January 2011 launch date. We wouldn't suggest you wait for 3G services to roll out and then consider buying a handset. Go ahead, buy a 3G enabled phone. The services provided will have nothing to do with your handset. And may we add, according to Bharti Airtel CEO Sanjay Kapoor, 3G services will not be cheap by any standards.

Operating systems

The other technical aspect of cell phones that has gained prominence in recent months is the underlying operating system. A couple of years ago, very few people knew what operating system their cell phone was running. Every third person was buying either the Symbian-based Nokia phones or other phones running a firmware. Then there were the proprietary OSes from iPhone and BlackBerry.

